

The College Search: How Transition Professionals Can Help Students with Intellectual Disability Find the Right College

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 **ThinkCollege**
NATIONAL COORDINATING CENTER



Think College National Coordinating Center is a project of the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston. The Center is funded by the US Department of Education, Office of Postsecondary Education, Grant #P407815002.



Changing Expectations. Increasing Opportunities.

Think College is a national organization dedicated to developing, expanding, and improving research and practice in inclusive higher education for people with intellectual disability.

www.ThinkCollege.net

The Think College website is a trusted source for information, training, and resources related to inclusive higher education for students with intellectual disability.

The website includes:

- A searchable program directory to learn more about available college options
- A resource library that includes published research as well as field-created tools and resources
- Online learning modules on a variety of topics
- Research to practice briefs, e-newsletters, and journal articles
- Topical information on the critical issues
- A policy and legislation clearinghouse



College Options for Students with Intellectual Disability

Steps in the college search

- Know the options
- Plan and conduct your search
- Dig deeper and ask questions
- Visit and apply

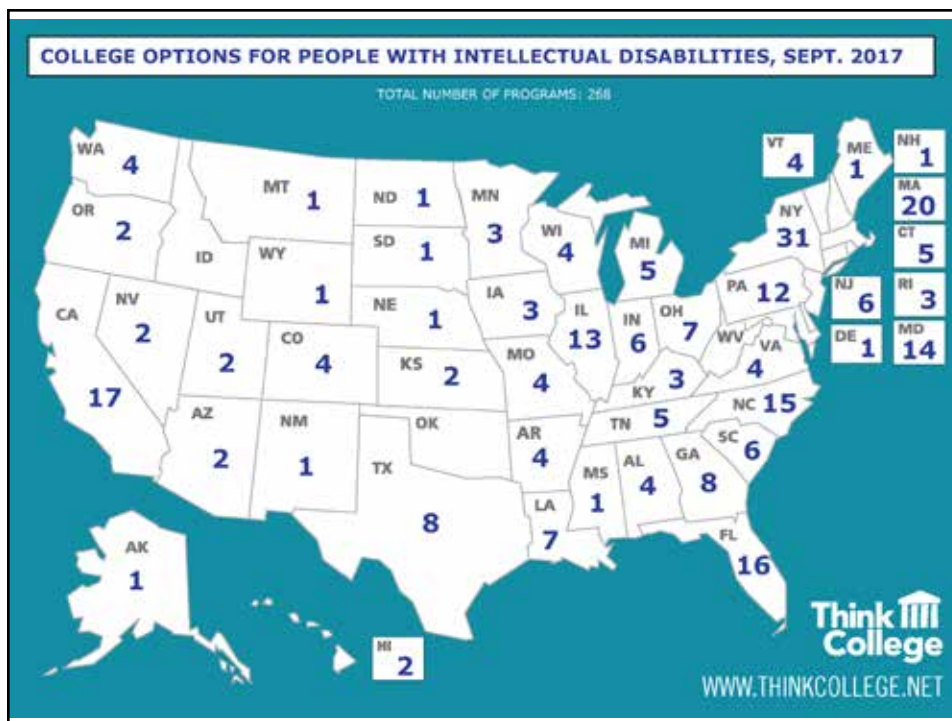
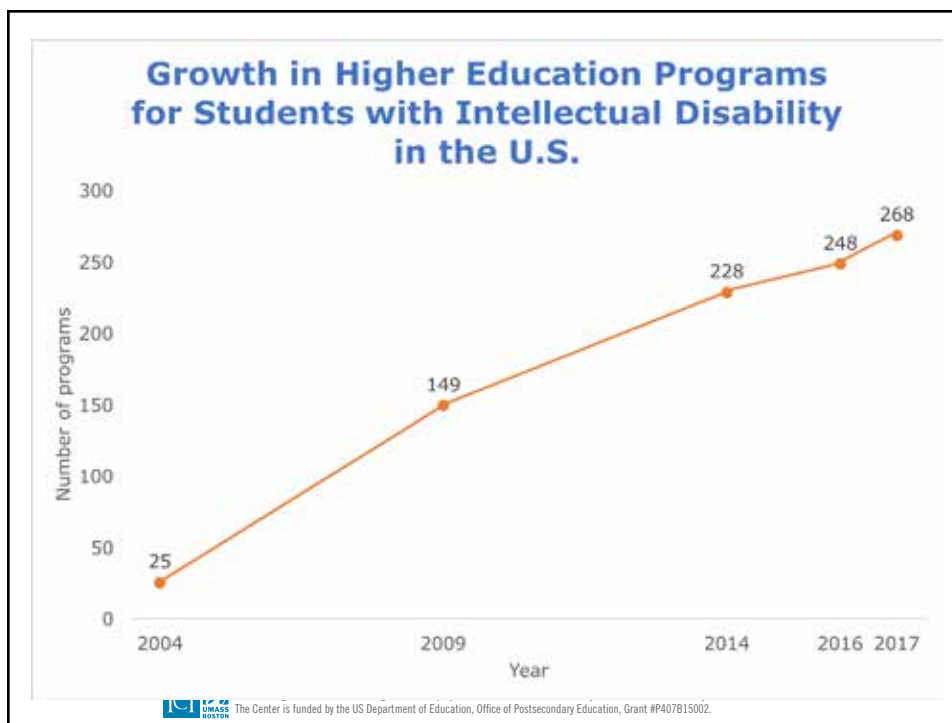


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Step 1: Know the Options



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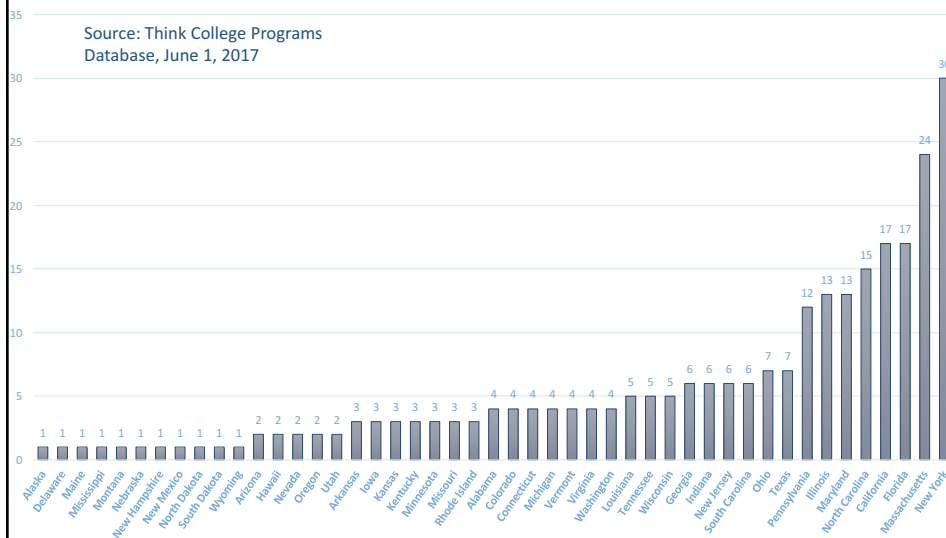




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Number of IHE Programs by State

Source: Think College Programs Database, June 1, 2017



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Type of institution

- 101 at 2-year IHE
- 137 at 4-year IHE
- 10 at technical school



61

(23%) offer federal
financial aid

72

(27%) offer
housing

Source: Think College Programs
Database, June 1, 2017

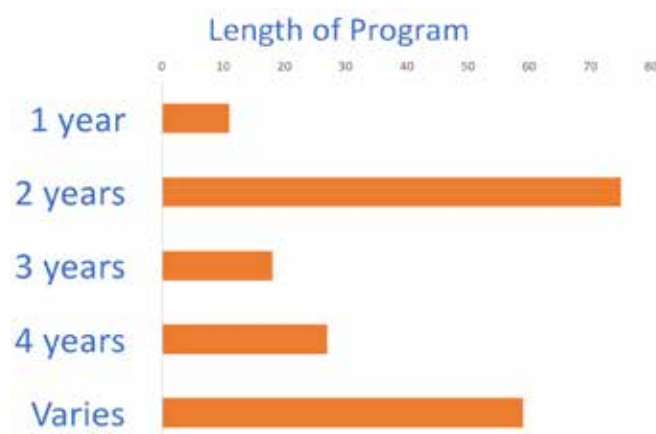


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Costs In 2015-16:

\$11,013 average annual program cost

Source: Think College Programs
Database, June 1, 2017



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Students

Source: Think College Programs
Database, June 1, 2017



Number of students in program

- Mean = 25
- Median = 15

Acceptance rate

- Mean = 69%

Disability

- 254 enroll students with ID
- 200 enroll students with ID and autism

Type of students served

- 52 serve only high school students
- 129 serve only students who have exited high school
- 81 serve both



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Academics

At 139 programs,
students take
inclusive classes
for credit

At 163 programs,
students take
inclusive classes
for audit

At 94 programs,
students take
continuing
education classes

123 programs offer
special classes

122 programs
award a credential

Source: Think College Programs
Database, June 1, 2017



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Employment (2015-2016)

39% of students had paid, integrated employment

57% of program completers from previous year
had paid, integrated employment within 90 days of exit

Source: Think College Programs
Database, June 1, 2017



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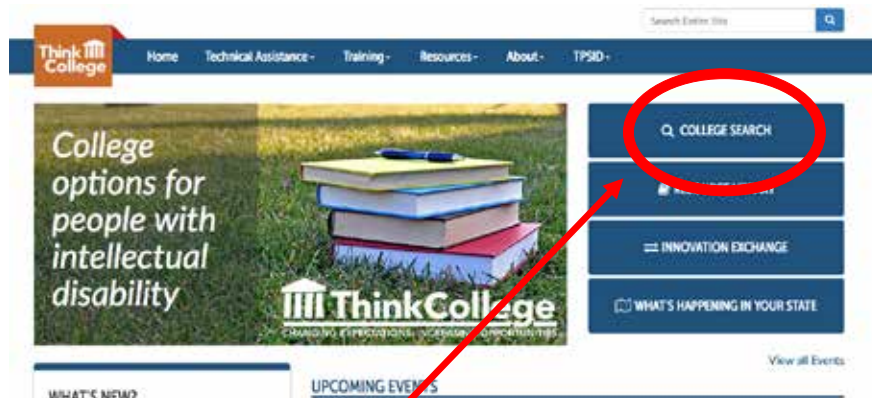
Step 2: Plan and conduct your search



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Use the Think College Programs Database to narrow down options

Go to www.thinkcollege.net



CLICK HERE



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SAVED

Click the "Save" Button to add a program to this list.

SEARCH CLEAR

Program or Keyword SHOW ALL

LOCATION

- ☐ Alabama (4)
- ☐ Alaska (1)
- ☐ Arizona (2)
- ☒ Show more states

PROGRAM FEATURES

- ☐ Serves Students in High School *
- ☐ Offers Financial Aid
- ☐ Offers Housing

*Note that students who are dually enrolled might not be eligible for financial aid or housing.

ADVANCED FILTERS

Find the college that's right for you!

Find and compare information on 268 college programs for students with intellectual disabilities! Search by program name, location, and other keywords. See "Advanced Filters" for more options to help you narrow your search and build a list of schools that are a good match for you.

Once you have located colleges you are interested in, download the How To Think College Guide to Conducting a College Search (PDF). It provides you with the right questions to ask in order to get the answers you need about each program on your list.

Click on map to show all programs in a state

Basic filters

- Location (State)
- Program features
 - Serves Students in High School
 - Offers Financial Aid
 - Offers Housing

- *Note that students who are dually enrolled might not be eligible for financial aid or housing

SEARCH CLEAR

Program or Keyword

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[Show more states](#)

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ADVANCED FILTERS



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Advanced filters

ADVANCED FILTERS

DISABILITY

☐ Intellectual disability

☐ Autism

☐ Other disabilities

PUBLIC OR PRIVATE

☐ Private

☐ Public

TYPE OF SCHOOL

☐ 2-year community college or junior college

☐ 4-year college or university

☐ Technical or vocational/trade school

☐ Other

PLANNED LENGTH OF PROGRAM

☐ 1 year

☐ 2 years

☐ 3 years

☐ 4 years

☐ Varies from student to student

☐ Program is a federally funded TPSID program



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Step 3: Dig deeper and ask questions

- Read carefully through the program's website
- Set up a phone call to ask questions.
- Attend an open house



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Admissions/Student Profile

What kinds of disabilities do students in the program have?

What percentage of students who enroll are students with ID?

How many students apply each year? How many are accepted?



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Other Question Topics (see Handout 1 on app)

- Residential access
- Services and Supports
- Fees, Tuition & Financial Aid
- Program Administration
- Communication with families
- Integration with the campus community
- Career Development & Employment
- Student Credentials
- Student Outcomes



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Step 3: Visit and apply!

- Visit your top choices to see the campus and meet the staff, faculty, and students.
- Visit the disability services office to see how involved that office is with the program.
- Connect with alumni and their families to learn about their experiences at college and what they're doing now.
- Apply!



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What can you do for students who are interested in college?

- Talk with students and families about IHE options
 - Show them the College Search webpage
 - Give them a copy of the How to Think College handout on conducting a college search
- Build college-related goals into the IEP
- Support students in college visits and applications



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Tips for Transition Professionals

Set high expectations

Provide families with information and resources

Encourage student participation in transition planning

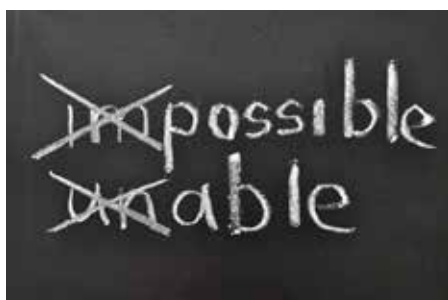
Teach self-advocacy, navigation, and safety skills

Help students transition to the college environment

Based on Griffin & Papay (2017) Supporting students with intellectual and developmental disabilities to attend college. *Teaching Exceptional Children*, 49, 411-419



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“Expectations are an extremely powerful force in determining whether a young person goes to college. And they are equally, if not more powerful, in determining if young people with an intellectual disability will go to college”

(Grigal & Hart, 2012, p. 221).



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What do you believe?



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Do you BELIEVE your
students can go to
college?



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Provide families with information and resources

Help families think about

Getting what they want for their child

VS.

What is available



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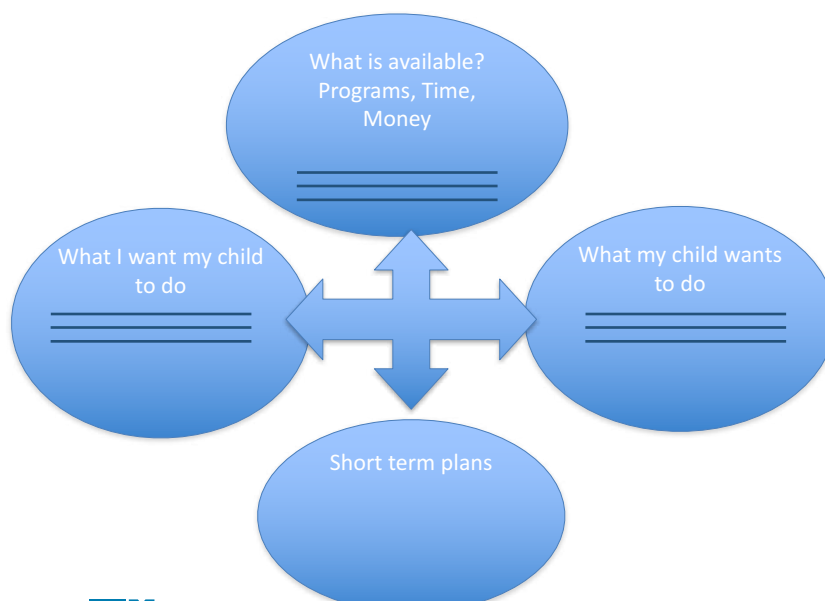
Know what's out there

- What is available in your community?
- What isn't available in your community?
- How far are you willing to go to get it?



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College Priorities: Mapping What's Possible



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Encourage student participation in transition planning

- Write College Exploration into IEP (for IEP goal ideas see Handout 3)
- Support students to advocate for **their** goals
 - Input / leadership in developing the IEP
 - Practice articulating support needs
 - Create multiple means of sharing (e.g. http://www.imdetermined.org/resources/detail/jermals_one_pager)



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Teach self-advocacy, navigation, and safety skills

ME! Curriculum – Zarrow center

Navigation →



Safety

- 1) Cellphone use
- 2) Model skills, practice, teach in real settings
(Grigal et al., 2012; Papay & Bambara, 2011).



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Help students transition to the college environment

• Differences

High school (IDEA)	College (ADA, Section 504)
Entitled to a free, appropriate public education	Protect against discrimination and ensure accessibility
Schools have legal obligation to identify all students with disabilities	Students must self-disclose and provide documentation of disability
IEP – accommodations, modifications, etc.	Access and appropriate accommodations for classes taken for credit

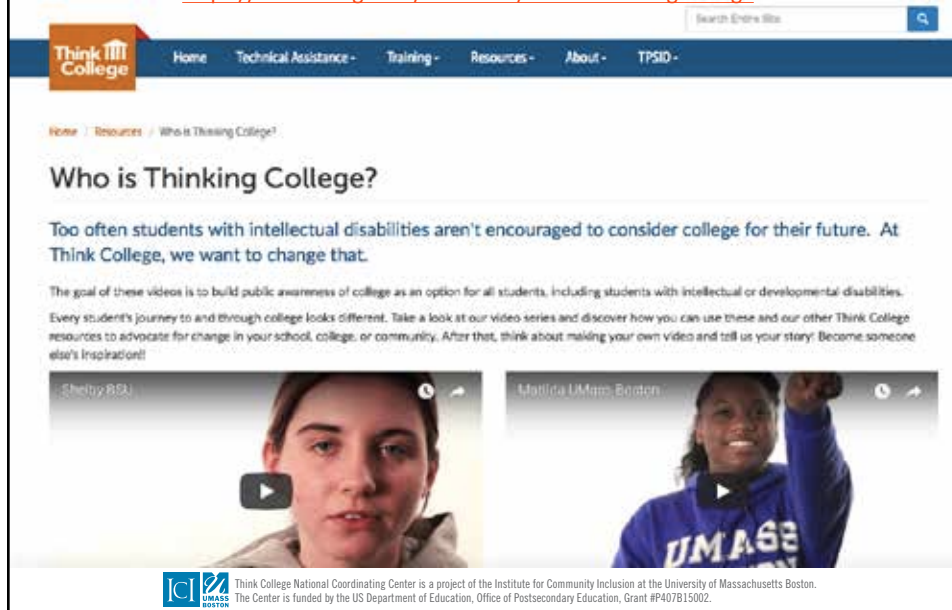
- Share information –students, families, college
- Look for opportunities to experience college firsthand



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Getting the Word Out!

Available at: <https://thinkcollege.net/resources/who-is-thinking-college>



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IN TOUCH**

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